BA AND THE DRAUGHTY HOUSE

England — a joined family in a draughty Victorian house



For Ba, and for the children who ran up the stairs.

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Ba's bedroom window and sari-draped chair



The draughty house and our rules

I grew up in England and some of my earliest memories are of living in a draughty Victorian house with my family and the family of my dad's older brother and Ba, my diabetic, dessert-demanding grandmother. When the moms cooked food for all 11 of us, they made food for us. They made a special menu for Ba because of her condition and they also made a special menu for my uncle because he liked his things his way. At mealtimes, Ba and her sons ate first and sometimes they were joined by the oldest and most golden grandson. And then after they were done, the moms and the rest of us kids would eat. There were also other rules. For example, my mother, as the wife of the second-ranking son, was expected to cover her face with her sari and be silent whenever Ba or my uncle were in the room. We continued to live in our joined family until Ba decides that her sons can live separately.

The fog, the pinch, and shouting

I remember one day when I was about five years old and Ba just starts screaming from upstairs, And I bapre, fog bog gharibi sheh, awo kado kado, which means, Good God! There is fog in my room, get it out! So we run upstairs like crazy people because when Ba screams, that's what you do. And there's no fog. It is a bright, sunny day. The diabetes has made Ba blind. It's a few months after Ba goes blind and because I'm five and my next cousin is six, we think it might be sort of interesting if we were to sneak into Ba's room to see if she could tell we were there. So we do. We creep in and of course Ba knows and she's, "Koncheh bol!" Which is, who's there? Speak! Well we're, you know, we're five and six, we're cool, we don't speak. We just wait until Ba falls back asleep. Then we decide it would be kind of cool if we pinched Ba. I pinched my blind grandmother. I reach out and I turn hard and she screams. We run out, the rest of the family is charging up the stairs.

The slap, my mother, and goodbyes

They are led by my uncle, whose most important job in the world is to honor and protect his mother. My cousin and I, we like run back in the room like, what's upsetting Ba so much? And she's screaming, Chokrito nakami badi, kalimaru loitiwa areche! Which roughly translates as, small girls are parasites. They don't do housework and only know how to suck my blood. I look over at my mom to kind of gauge like how busted I am and she does not look upset. So I give her like a very small, very secret smile. But that is when my uncle's hand slaps me so hard across the head that I fall backwards. His hand is still raised in fury when I hear my mother's voice. It sounds like ice water. You have no right. I just surrender to an epic meltdown. Ba eventually dies. And then when I'm 12, my parents announce, we are moving to America.

When he stands, there are tears in his eyes. And I know in America, I'm going to have a very different life than my mother has had.


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